

Why I disagree with the anti ai energy argument (alliteration :)

Posted by u/DannyisDannny • 0 points • 19 comments

The energy stuff is kinda blown out of proportion. It takes 0.011kWh for an AI image, which is around 25% less than what a low-end energy consumption tablet uses in an hour (15 watt tablet). This gets even worse when you consider other devices, like laptops or desktops, which are used a lot for things like 3D art (Tablets are 15-30W, laptops are 30-70W, desktop computers are 200-300W, there's 0.0001kWh per watt per hour of usage). I'm not really an artist, I've done a bit, but I know that it definitely takes quite a bit more than one hour to make a detailed piece. There are some trade offs, ai takes the same amount energy for different amounts of detail, so a more detailed image would be better energy-wise if made by ai, but many people who use ai image makers usually generate more than one image for the final result. Making an image with a single line costs basically nothing for the digital artist, but costs 0.011kWh for the ai image, while making a detailed image could cost 0.09-1.8kWh, depending on the device, if it took the digital artist 6 hours, while it would still cost 0.011kWh for the ai. Comparing digital art and ai images, ai is usually better for energy consumption, especially when the artist takes longer than 45 minutes.

Comments

u/NegativeEmphasis • 5 points • 2025-05-14 22:22 UTC

The power usage argument manages to be even more stupid than the "collage machine" one, which is almost a feat by itself.

I mean, not everybody can understand the math behind how Diffusion works, but a lot of people can download a model that fits on consumer hardware, run it by themselves and SEE the impact, if any, that will have on their power bill.

Having done that for a couple of years now, running diffusion locally turns out to be a less expensive hobby than PC gaming. My computer draws ****more power**** when I'm in a Baldur's Gate 3 binge (sorry, the game looks like ass with low graphics mode) than when I'm creating pictures with Diffusion. Both processes pull about the same amount of power when doing their work, but at ****worst**** Diffusion spends like 5 minutes generating a batch of 20 or 30 pictures of some idea which are then followed by like 30 minutes of me cleaning up the best results in Krita/Photoshop (which consume less power than games or Diffusion). That's not to mention the 5-10 minutes of coming up with an idea and working on the prompt / settings.

Meanwhile, when I'm playing BG3 (curse the patch 8 who made me go through the game again to finally play an "official" bladesinger class), BG3 is consuming all that power, all the time, **"for hours"**. Power consumption goes down somewhat when you have the inventory overlay open, but otherwise the graphics card stays with fan ablaze for how many hours as you're playing. And it's the same for CoD, or FIFA, or Gran Turismo, or about any other graphics intensive, "AAA game". You know, that big hobby for a large segment of people.

u/JaggedMetalOs • -3 points • 2025-05-14 22:16 UTC

Individuals generating individual images is indeed inconsequential, but what adds up is huge datacenters running hundreds of millions of dollars of GPUs continuously for training and companies running billions of unsolicited AI queries per day (eg. Google AI Overview)

u/ChomsGP • 2 points • 2025-05-14 23:54 UTC

All due respect, Google burns way more electricity serving you ads than it does generating the AI summary

u/JaggedMetalOs • 2 points • 2025-05-15 00:56 UTC

Google's own AI says it likely uses significantly more power than a regular (including ads) search

> Google AI Overviews, while part of the larger Google Search, don't have a single, isolated energy consumption figure. However, it's estimated that AI-powered search queries, like those involving Overviews, can use significantly more energy than a standard text-based search. One study estimated that each AI-powered search query could require 7-9 watt-hours of energy, which is 23-30 times more than a regular search.

u/ChomsGP • 1 points • 2025-05-15 10:27 UTC

Well, for one the AI summary, as the name says, summarizes several searches 🤔 you can't compare them 1 to 1 because it saves you from opening each link and finding the information which is not just the search but also serving all assets from the pages you visit

It is WAY more energy consuming

Even if it had the same or bigger footprint, you get way more ads than summaries, including those YouTube ads inside videos that requires transcoding (a compute heavy operation)

And of course Google is going to downplay the ecological footprint of what drives most of it's revenue

u/JaggedMetalOs • 1 points • 2025-05-15 11:04 UTC

> Well, for one the AI summary, as the name says, summarizes several searches 🤔 you can't compare them 1 to 1 because it saves you from opening each link and finding the information which is not just the search but also serving all assets from the pages you visit

Of course I can compare because *I didn't ask for it*. It gets added to every single search whether I need to open multiple links to find something, whether I can easily go to the single link I need, whether I can get the answer just from the site summary on the result page without even opening anything, or whether it's telling me something stupid like to put glue on my pizza.

u/ChomsGP • 1 points • 2025-05-15 11:11 UTC

So now you are complaining about the quality of service? xD

And I didn't ask for the ads either, I'm not sure what your point is there

u/JaggedMetalOs • 1 points • 2025-05-15 13:32 UTC

The point is it is adding a lot of power use to billions of search queries, so it doesn't matter that an individual person running an individual image generation doesn't use much power on its own.

u/ChomsGP
• 1 points •
2025-05-15
13:41 UTC

Again, so what? You are also spending how many hours on reddit? Most apps have a bazillion pointless features that are just flashy things to attract users and serve no other purpose

The 500 guys that are fine with just the AI summary makes for your consumption clicking around stuff 🤖

u/Xdivine • 1 points • 2025-05-15 08:16 UTC

Google's AI is just a fancy google search; it doesn't have any information of its own. It basically just does a search and then tries to parse what it thinks is the most relevant info from various results. It has no more information than has been publicly released, so you might as well just have linked the study quoted instead of trying to act like it coming from 'Google's own AI' means anything.

u/Pigeon_of_Doom_ • 4 points • 2025-05-14 23:34 UTC

Training AI, a task that happens once every few months, takes the same amount of resources as flying a single plane for one week. Once you put it like that, it's quite clear that AI isn't using a significant amount at all.

u/JaggedMetalOs • 2 points • 2025-05-15 01:06 UTC

You think they just leave hundreds of millions of dollars of GPU idle for months on end? Companies like OpenAI wouldn't be asking to build multiple "5 gigawatt" datacenters if they were only running them at capacity occasionally.

u/AccomplishedNovel6 • 6 points • 2025-05-15 00:45 UTC

Not to mention that training doesn't only affect one person, it's benefits are spread across the entirety of the userbase. Per capita, it's absolutely trivial.

u/ai-illustrator • 4 points • 2025-05-14 23:29 UTC

the solution to which is open source ai. support and propagate open source ai, nothing else will stop the megacorps.

u/jay-ff • 1 points • 2025-05-15 08:33 UTC

A data Center, all else considered, is more efficient than your Pc at home.

u/JaggedMetalOs • -2 points • 2025-05-15 01:09 UTC

Yeah but there's no major open source models anywhere close to being self trained, all the open models currently rely on being trained by these big private companies with hundreds of millions of dollars worth of GPU compute.

u/ai-illustrator • 3 points • 2025-05-15 01:40 UTC



And? It won't be long until personal hardware catches up to run open source model training. Maybe like two to five years tops.

Open source software designed by close source AI models is exploding - anyone can make anything with llms and share it. Leaning and sharing it is what actually makes a difference.